

Prototype Innovation

Video Prototype Link: <https://youtube.com/shorts/tZSPobbayYg?feature=share>

Essay

For this assignment, I created a video prototype for a voice-based cooking assistant called Darby with the slogan "Just Ask. Just Cook." Darby is designed to help users navigate the cooking process through voice commands. Users can ask Darby to find recipes, provide cooking instructions, control smart kitchen appliances, answer cooking-related questions, and set timers by just using their voice and without needing to touch a screen or device. I chose to create a video prototype because it allowed me to demonstrate the voice interactions and overall user experience the best.

If I were continuing the design process, I would use several different types of prototypes to explore the product further. I would begin with storyboards to map out common user scenarios and identify key interactions between the user and Darby. As the design matured, I would create higher-fidelity prototypes with realistic voice responses and simulated smart appliance controls. These methods are appropriate because they allow designers to test ideas quickly and gather feedback without spending significant time and resources on implementation.

One approach I would not choose early on is building a fully functional prototype. While it might look impressive, it would require a lot of effort to develop voice recognition, appliance integration, and natural language processing. Throughout this course, we learned that we should start with simpler prototypes (low- and medium-fidelity prototypes) that are less time-consuming, less expensive, and just require fewer resources in general. After the early stages, we can continue to develop higher fidelity prototypes that are closer to the finished product.

Three things about prototyping that I will remember after taking this course are, first, a prototype does not need to be fully functional to be effective. Second, different prototype fidelities serve different purposes, and choosing the right one depends on what you are trying to learn. Finally, user feedback is one of the most important parts of the design process. A design may seem good on paper, but testing it with users often reveals issues and opportunities for improvement that would otherwise be missed. Overall, this course helped me see prototyping as a way to explore ideas, gather feedback, and improve designs before investing significant time and resources into development.